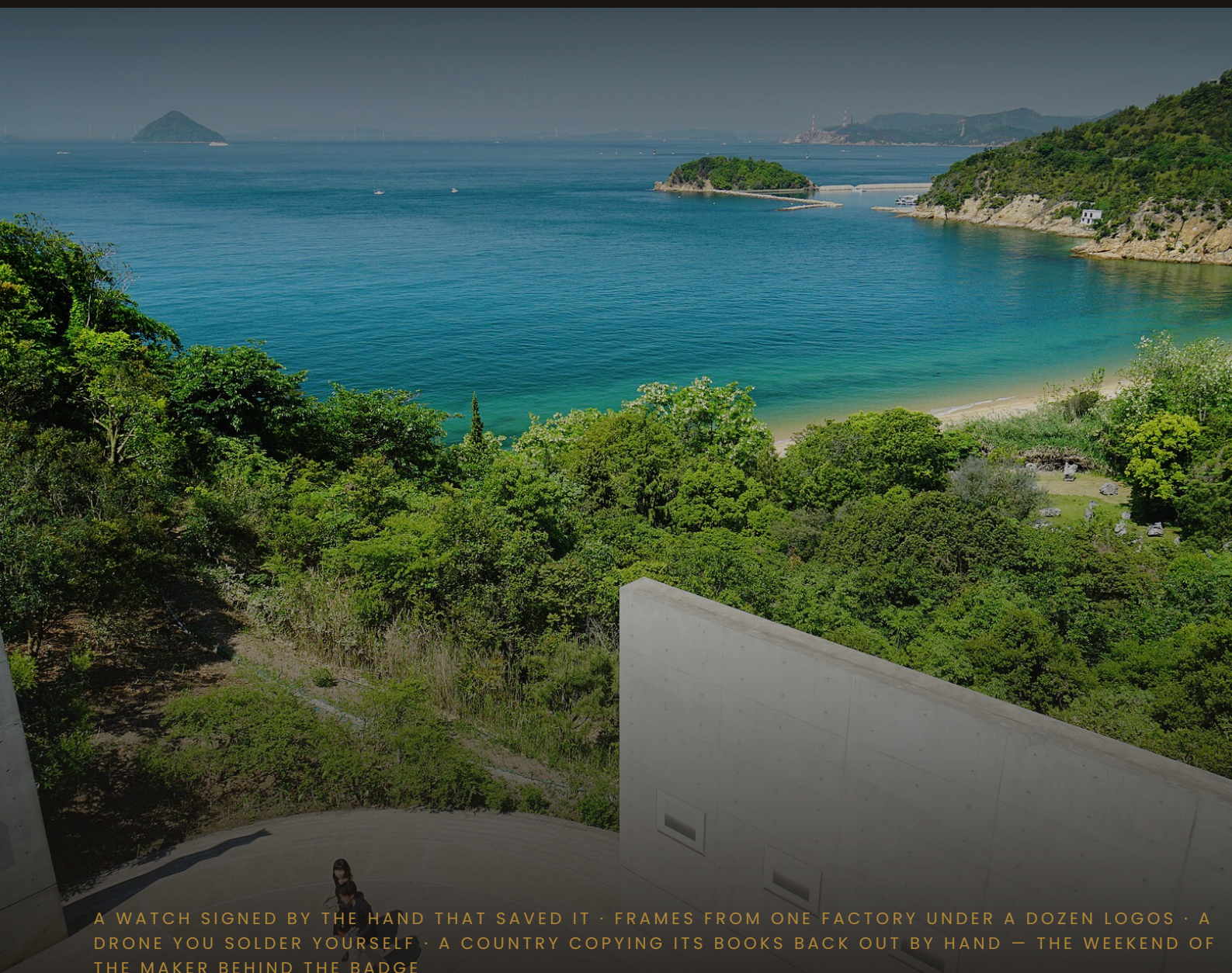


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 30 AUGUST 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



A WATCH SIGNED BY THE HAND THAT SAVED IT · FRAMES FROM ONE FACTORY UNDER A DOZEN LOGOS · A DRONE YOU SOLDER YOURSELF · A COUNTRY COPYING ITS BOOKS BACK OUT BY HAND — THE WEEKEND OF THE MAKER BEHIND THE BADGE

THE GOOD LIFE

A watch built from a genuine 1970s movement, refinished by hand and signed on the bridge — the case for provenance over the spec sheet

THE RABBIT HOLE

FPV drones: the one flying machine you build and solder yourself, the goggles that put you in the cockpit, and Singapore's hard rules for the air

THE ATELIER

Eyewear, from the acetate up — and the open secret that a dozen "designer" frames come off one conglomerate's line

THIS ISSUE · THE WEEKEND BOOK

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FROM THE DESK

"The hand is the cutting edge of the mind."

— Jacob Bronowski, *The Ascent of Man* (1973)¹

Bronowski meant it literally: we think by making. The weekend's book keeps returning to the hand behind the object — the watchmaker who signs a movement he refinished (p10), the Sabae bench that hand-polishes a frame over days (p6), the pilot who solders his own aircraft (p15), and a Korean generation copying novels out by hand precisely because a machine now writes for free (p25). The badge is easy. The hand is the part you cannot outsource.

THE STRIP — AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL
VWRA (All-World)	~US\$195 ▲
Gold (spot)	~US\$4,600
Bitcoin	~US\$80k ▼
US 10-year	~4.72% ▲
US dollar (DXY)	~99.7 ▲
Brent crude	~US\$88 ▼

US close, Fri 28 Aug 2026; markets shut over the weekend. Gold holding within a whisker of its 24 Aug record (~US\$4,712) even as the dollar firmed. Context, not advice.²

THE WEEKEND IN NUMBERS

Six months. How long the Strait of Hormuz has now been shut to routine traffic — the longest closure of the oil chokepoint on record. — **p3**

692.8 per cent. The year-on-year jump in sales of hand-copying "pilsa" books at Korea's biggest chain — a nation transcribing its way out of the age of the machine. — **p25**

Six hundred and ninety-two per cent, thirty-one years apart. The yellow pumpkin on Naoshima's pier has stood since 1994, was washed to sea by a typhoon in 2021, and was rebuilt ten per cent thicker to stand again. — **p21**

Zero. Cameras on the weekend's most-talked-about smart glasses — the feature is the one they left out. — **p9**

Fifty. Steel pieces of a new chronograph built on a restored 1970s movement and signed, on the bridge, by the workshop that saved it. — **p10**

Fifty-six per cent. The market-implied odds, by Friday's close, of a September rate rise — a hike the year had all but written off. — **p14**

SOURCES 1. Jacob Bronowski, *The Ascent of Man* (BBC/Little, Brown, 1973), ch. 3. 2. TradingEconomics; CNBC; USAGOLD; FXStreet — levels around the US close, Fri 28 Aug 2026; gold near its 24 Aug record ~US\$4,712. Market data is context, not investment advice.

THE WORLD · THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

Washington Declares an Economic War. Tehran Sends Back a Bill.

Six months into the longest closure of the oil chokepoint on record, Washington has stopped threatening and started naming — a structured sanctions campaign aimed not at Iran alone but at the buyers, banks and shippers that keep it solvent. Iran's reply was not a key to the strait but a bill: compensation, an unfrozen economy, an end to the war.

this story  

It began as rhetoric and hardened into policy. After a Sunday-night "economic D-Day" promise, the US Treasury secretary unveiled at a Monday press conference a named isolation campaign — the toughest yet — reaching past Iran to the buyers, banks and networks that fund the regime.¹ The codename signals permanence — a policy, not a tweet — though whether it moves a single tanker is another matter.

Iran answered in kind. Tehran published its price — lift the blockade, pay war-damage compensation, unfreeze assets, drop sanctions, end the war — and the Revolutionary Guard restated that the lane stays

shut until an earlier, now-expired understanding is honoured.² The demands are maximalist by design — leverage banked for talks that have not started.

The one crack of daylight is a corridor. Tehran and Muscat have drawn a safe-transit lane through Omani water — inbound Iranian, outbound Omani, revenue split — and oil slipped to a two-week low the day the proposal surfaced.³ The lane is charted; no convoy has yet sailed it. Washington's own line, held for weeks, is that the strait is "already open." The water agrees with neither: a tenth of the usual traffic moves.

~180

DAYS THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ HAS BEEN SHUT TO ROUTINE TRAFFIC — THE LONGEST CLOSURE ON RECORD OF THE LANE THAT NORMALLY CARRIES ABOUT A FIFTH OF THE WORLD'S SEABORNE OIL; BRENT SITS NEAR US\$88, OFF A ~US\$118 MARCH SPIKE⁴

THE MARKET READ NEW YORK · FORTUNE / CNBC

Economic gravity against political will. Analysts once modelled oil above two hundred; China's stockpiling has held Brent near half — a cushion that thins each month the lane stays shut.⁴

THE BEIJING READ BEIJING · GLOBAL TIMES / MOFA

Coercion that raises everyone's bill. The foreign ministry's line, in state media, is that pressuring third countries "will only further intensify tensions" and that legitimate China-Iran trade should not be disrupted.⁵

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRACKERS SAY

Shipping desks read the Omani corridor as the pressure valve, not the surrender the codename implies; oil's dip suggests the market prices a managed reopening, not a spiral.

CGEP-Columbia; Bruegel; Fortune — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · A CODENAME IS NOT A CONVOY

Read it in proportion. A campaign aimed at buyers and banks hardens Iran's stance as fast as it bites, and China — its main customer — has signalled it will not comply. The falsifier is not a press conference but a first ship that sails the corridor.⁶

CNN (18 Aug); Fox (26 Aug) — characterised

SOURCES 1. CNN live, 23 Aug 2026 ("economic D-Day"); CBS News, 24 Aug 2026 (Treasury sanctions campaign targeting third-country buyers/banks) — operation name lightly sourced, flagged. 2. Al Jazeera, 28 Aug 2026 (Iran's published terms); Washington Times, 26 Aug 2026 (IRGC: closed until the earlier MoU is honoured); CNBC, 24 Aug 2026 (ship-detention warning). 3. Fox News, 26 Aug 2026 (Iran-Oman corridor; oil to a two-week low); corridor claim originates in Iranian state media, not independently verified. 4. Fortune, 10 Jun 2026 (China's buffer; ~US\$118 March peak); US EIA (Hormuz ~one-fifth of seaborne oil); TradingEconomics (Brent ~US\$88, 28 Aug); OSINT tanker trackers, attributed. 5. Global Times / China MOFA line, Aug 2026, carried in state media — reported speech, not verified verbatim. 6. CNN live, 18 Aug 2026 (strait "already open"; "no talks"); Fox News, 26 Aug 2026.

THE WORLD · THE PACIFIC & BEYOND

Three Navies Rehearse Off Jeju as a Himalayan Flood Turns a Second Corner

The trilateral "Freedom Edge" drill is set for early September in the waters south of Jeju; a glacial-lake flood on the Nepal–Tibet frontier has passed six hundred dead and now threatens a second surge. A weekend's reminder that the region's map of leisure and its map of risk share coordinates.

Three navies will drill together off Jeju. The American, South Korean and Japanese fleets hold the third round of "Freedom Edge" from about 7 September in the sea south of the island, folding missile-defence, sub-hunting and air work into one exercise they used to run only two at a time.¹ Pyongyang, which brands the whole arrangement an embryonic "Asian NATO," has promised a "corresponding" answer, and the rehearsal goes ahead regardless. Read the danger as an accident on the water, not the plan.

The Himalayan disaster deepened. A glacial-lake burst on the Nepal–Tibet frontier has now killed more than six hundred, left thousands unaccounted for, and left behind a fresh hazard — a pool ponded behind the debris whose failure would send another

>600

THE HIMALAYAN FLOOD TOLL AND STILL CLIMBING, WITH THOUSANDS UNACCOUNTED FOR; THE SECOND-ORDER THREAT IS A DEBRIS-DAMMED BARRIER LAKE, A SLOWER DANGER THAN THE FIRST SURGE²

surge down the same valley.² No storm came first; the trigger sat far upslope, across the border, where a glacier simply gave way. The count is still moving and differs between sources.

Two running threads each gained a line and little more. Moscow has at last acknowledged on the record the spy-agency channel that carried America's intelligence chief to the Russian capital last week — the trip this desk led on — settling that the meeting happened without disclosing what it yielded.³ And Beijing has lodged a formal protest against a mooted extra 7.5 per cent duty even as both governments pencil in a leaders' summit for 24 September: the penalty and the photograph, booked a fortnight apart.⁴

THE CHATTER · THE REGION'S OVERLAPPING MAPS

The week's through-line is that the Pacific's holiday map and its threat map keep sharing coordinates — the sea off Jeju is a dive site and a rehearsal range at once, and the tariff Washington is drafting is timed a fortnight before the summit it shadows. Deterrence and diplomacy, run on one calendar.

desk read — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · THE DRILL IS THE MESSAGE

Keep the exercise in scale. "Freedom Edge" is a signalling instrument — a telegraphed, scheduled rehearsal whose purpose is deterrence — and Pyongyang's "corresponding response" is the ritual reply, not a mobilisation. The calendar item is leverage, the same currency as the tariff two paragraphs up; the danger is an accident, not the plan.⁵

Yonhap; Reuters — characterised

IN BRIEF · AROUND THE WORLD

Kyiv. An overnight Russian barrage of drones and missiles hit the Ukrainian capital and other centres; the city reported casualties, and its government renewed the plea to partners for air-defence interceptors.⁶ **The Gulf.** Beyond Hormuz, Doha's

shuttle reached a further Gulf capital — the third mediator to enter the file inside a fortnight. **Brussels.** Europe's biometric border checks are running; the paid travel permit is pushed to 2027 (see p19).

SOURCES 1. Japan Times; UPI; SCMP — "Freedom Edge" trilateral drill, ~7–11 Sep 2026, waters off Jeju; DPRK "corresponding response" statement, late Aug 2026. 2. CNN, 28 Aug 2026 (thousands missing); HNGN, 28 Aug 2026 (toll ~633); WSWS, 29 Aug 2026 (barrier-lake watch) — figures vary by source, flagged. 3. Kremlin/TASS confirmation of Ratcliffe intelligence talks, Aug 2026; CNN; Washington Post — advancing MERIDIAN No. 86. 4. Bloomberg; Semafor — China objection to a +7.5% tariff; leaders' summit reported 24 Sep 2026. 5. Yonhap; Reuters — deterrence framing, characterised. 6. Euronews; Al Jazeera — Kyiv strikes, late Aug 2026; European Commission (EES live; ETIAS 2027).

SINGAPORE · THE TWO-SPEED ECONOMY

The Factories Grew Again. The Growth Got Narrower.

July's manufacturing print was another gain — and another quiet warning. The number is carried almost entirely by the AI-chip cycle; strip out electronics and precision engineering and the picture is of clusters going backwards. The relief cheques land next week against an economy leaning hard on a single engine.

this story  

Read the headline and it is a good month. Manufacturing output rose 6.8 per cent on the year in July, the eleventh straight month of expansion.¹ Read the breakdown and it narrows fast. The gain is an electronics story — semiconductors and their supply chain, riding the same AI build-out that carried Nvidia's quarter (p7) — and even electronics cooled to an eleven-month-low pace. Take the chips away and the engine stalls: biomedical output fell, and chemicals fell harder.

The concentration is the risk. One narrow, globally-cyclical cluster is doing the work of a whole economy's growth line, which is fine while the cycle runs and precarious the moment it turns. It is the

same softness showing up elsewhere — in a labour market still adding jobs but shedding them too, and in a cost-of-living squeeze that a one-off transfer eases without curing.

The help, at least, is timely. The Cost-of-Living Special Payment — between four hundred and six hundred dollars a head to over 2.4 million citizens — is paid out through September, landing within days.² It sits on a record electricity tariff whose next revision, due around 30 September, still turns on a strait on the far side of Asia (p3), since almost all the grid burns imported gas. A closed lane on page three becomes, two pages on, a line on the power bill.

One narrow, cyclical cluster is doing the work of a whole economy's growth line.

+6.8%

JULY MANUFACTURING OUTPUT ON THE YEAR — BUT ELECTRONICS COOLED TO AN 11-MONTH-LOW PACE, WHILE BIOMEDICAL (-5.3%) AND CHEMICALS (-10.6%) WENT BACKWARDS¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE DESKS SAY

House economists keep the faith, if warily: a Maybank note read July's electronics moderation as a cooling, not the end of the AI upcycle. The mood on local threads is closer to the utilities bill — welcome the cheque, distrust it as a fix.

Maybank Investment Bank; Xinhua economist roundup — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · AN ENGINE IS NOT A PORTFOLIO

Concentration cuts both ways. An economy carried by one AI-linked cluster inherits that cluster's cycle — and its air pocket, when it comes. Chemicals and biomedical are already contracting, so there is little else holding the line if chips wobble. A transfer smooths a month; it does not diversify an economy.

desk judgement; EDB cluster data

STILL ON THE WIRE

Prices. July core inflation held at a four-year-high 2.0 per cent, the tariff still the pointer. **Housing.** HDB resale slipped 0.3 per cent in Q2, its first back-to-back fall since 2018–19, even as a record run of million-dollar flats cleared. **Jobs.** Retrenchments stayed at multi-year highs even as employment kept growing — the two-speed economy in one line.³

SOURCES 1. EDB, *Singapore Manufacturing Output July 2026* (+6.8% y/y; electronics +11.2%, an 11-month-low pace; biomedical -5.3%; chemicals -10.6%) — released 26 Aug 2026; Xinhua; Trading Economics. 2. Ministry of Finance — Cost-of-Living Special Payment (\$\$400–600 to >2.4m citizens, disbursed September 2026); +\$\$200 CDC vouchers per household. 3. MTI/AsiaOne (July core CPI 2.0%, headline 2.2%); EdgeProp/ERA (HDB RPI -0.3% Q2); MOM/MRSD 2Q2026 Labour Market Advance Release. Grid ~95% gas-fired; SP Group Q3 tariff record 31.91c/kWh, Q4 revision ~30 Sep.

THE ATELIER • EYEWEAR, FROM THE ACETATE UP

A Dozen Logos, One Factory Line: Buy the Frame by Its Maker, Not Its Badge

Eyewear is the purest test of this desk's thesis: the material that decides whether a frame lasts costs a rounding error, the hinge that decides its life is invisible on the shelf, and the "designer" name on the temple is usually a licence printed on a mass-produced unit from one of five conglomerates.

this story  

Start with the material, the fork that decides everything. Cheap frames are injection-moulded plastic with colour sprayed on the surface — hollow-feeling, seamed, the colour stopping where the scratch begins. Quality frames are cut from *cellulose acetate*, a plant-based sheet whose colour runs all the way through, then cut, tumbled and hand-polished over days at the Sabae benches in Japan; Mazzucchelli, in Italy since 1849, is the acetate the trade means by "Italian acetate."¹ In metal, the ladder climbs from monel — a copper-nickel base that greens with sweat — through stainless to titanium, which shrugs off perspiration and, pure, carries no nickel. The hinge is the clearest

~64¢

OF EVERY SALES DOLLAR BOOKED AS GROSS PROFIT BY THE EYEWEAR GIANT, ON A MUCH-CITED (AND DATED) FIGURE; A DESIGNER FRAME COSTS A ROUNDING ERROR TO MAKE AGAINST ITS SHELF PRICE³

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE OBSESSIVES LUST AFTER

Two frames run the forums. The Lindberg cult prizes the screwless titanium — "so light you forget you're wearing them"; the JMM thread splits between admirers of the Japanese craft and sceptics who call the numbered runs scarcity-pricing on frames from the same Sabae workshops others use at half the money.

StyleForum eyewear threads; opticians — characterised

tier-tell: count the barrels, or buy no screw at all — Lindberg's spiral hinge, 999.9's own titanium one.

Because the logo, increasingly, is the whole purchase. EssilorLuxottica makes or licenses eighty-plus names: it *owns* Ray-Ban, Oakley, Persol and Oliver Peoples, and it *licenses* — prints, for a royalty, on frames it manufactures — Chanel, Prada, Versace, Burberry and Dolce & Gabbana.² Kering Eyewear owns Lindberg and Maui Jim and licenses Gucci, Cartier and Saint Laurent; Safilo, Marcolin and Marchon carry the rest. Pick a Prada frame over a Versace one and you are choosing between two products off the same line.

THE SCEPTIC • WHERE THE PRICE IS THEATRE

The least flattering true claim in eyewear: a licensed-logo frame is largely brand tax, a badge on a unit off a shared line. Functional quality is essentially maxed by the US\$300–700 Sabae sweet spot; above it, Lindberg's engineering aside, you pay for design and rarity. Buy a Japanese bench and stop.

TIME (markup, dated); forum consensus — characterised

THE SHORTLIST & THE SINGAPORE BENCH

Sweet spot. Masunaga, 999.9, Eyevan 7285, Factory900; Lunor and Moscot in Europe. **Grail.** Lindberg, Jacques Marie Mage, Kirk & Kirk. **Singapore.** Visio Optical (Masunaga + Lindberg); Evershine and Four Nines SG (999.9); Jamco (JMM).⁴ In this climate, specify titanium — nose-pad arms included, the classic failure point.

NEXT ON THE BENCH • YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Cast-iron & carbon-steel cookware — the pan you season and hand down: De Buyer and Matfer against vintage Griswold and new Smithey.

Everyday backpacks — where the tech-carry reader lives: waxed canvas and ballistic nylon, and the designer-nylon tax.

Japanese selvedge denim — looms, mills and fade culture: maker-worship done right, from the shuttle loom up.

SOURCES 1. Bonlook; View Eyewear; maker craftsmanship notes (cellulose acetate vs injection; Mazzucchelli est. 1849; Sabae hand-polish; titanium vs monel) — indicative, Aug 2026. 2. The Brand Hopper; The Fashion Law; Kering Eyewear (owned vs licensed; EssilorLuxottica 80+ names; Kering owns Lindberg/Maui Jim). 3. TIME, "How Fat Is the Markup on Designer Sunglasses?" (2010, widely re-cited) — dated/contested, flagged. 4. Evershine Optical (999.9 SGD prices); Visio Optical; Jamco Optical (JMM, Fullerton) — indicative, Aug 2026.

TECHNOLOGY • THE CHALLENGER CHIP

A Buyer Builds Its Own Silicon — and Aims It at the Incumbent's Fattest Margin

OpenAI's first in-house inference chip, benchmarked publicly this week, is being read as a shot not at Nvidia's training empire but at the part that pays best: serving the models. The numbers, from a single analytics house, claim a real efficiency lead. The caveat is that the company making them is still Nvidia's largest customer.

this story  

The chip has a name and now a set of numbers. "Jalapeño," OpenAI's Broadcom-built inference accelerator — a reticle-sized part on a leading TSMC process, fed by the newest high-bandwidth memory — was benchmarked in a widely-circulated deep dive this week claiming it does between one-and-a-half and nearly two times the useful work of a competing Nvidia part at peak, with markedly lower latency and better performance per watt.¹ The framing was deliberate: this is aimed at *inference* — the business of answering prompts at scale — which is the fastest-growing and highest-margin slice of Nvidia's empire.

The sovereignty logic is the tell. When you are the world's largest renter of someone else's silicon, designing your own is how you stop paying rent on

1.5–1.9×

THE "AI WORK" PER PEAK THROUGHPUT JALAPEÑO IS CLAIMED TO DELIVER OVER A COMPETING NVIDIA PART, WITH 1.7–3.6× LOWER LATENCY — FIGURES FROM ONE ANALYTICS HOUSE, NOT INDEPENDENTLY MEASURED¹

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE ANALYSTS SAY

The read on the desks is that a hyperscaler-designed chip matching Blackwell-class efficiency on inference is a genuine first, and a real threat to the margin Nvidia earns on serving models. OpenAI's own chief called it, with studied understatement, a chip that "is fast." The counter-current: everyone who has tried custom silicon still buys Nvidia by the boatload.

Yole Group; SemiAnalysis — characterised

your fastest-growing cost. It is the same move, one layer down, that runs through this weekend's book: control the thing with your name on it rather than badge someone else's. Jalapeño deploys in "very small volumes" late this year and scales in 2027 — so the threat is a trajectory, not a quarter.

Nvidia's counterweight is the quarter it just printed: US\$96.2 billion in revenue, up more than a hundred per cent on the year (No. 86), with a data-centre order book that a single customer's ASIC does not empty.² The honest read is that the incumbent still owns training and the software moat around it; what is genuinely contested, for the first time, is whether it also owns inference — the part that was supposed to be forever.

THE SCEPTIC • ONE CHART, ONE VENDOR

Discount the numbers to their source. The benchmark leans on a single analytics house and on OpenAI's own framing; volumes this year are tiny; and OpenAI has said plainly it will keep buying Nvidia for both training and inference. Nvidia's chief waved it off — lots of chip projects get started. Custom silicon narrowing a margin is not the same as unseating a platform, and the software moat is untouched.

Benzinga (Cramer/Huang); company statements — characterised

STILL ON THE SHELF

The loophole. US enforcement is still probing how Chinese AI firms legally rent restricted Nvidia compute through third-country data centres in Thailand, Malaysia and Japan — the remote-access gap export controls never closed.³ **The counterweight.** Nvidia's guidance still excludes China sales, and its next-quarter outlook sat well above US\$100bn even without them.

SOURCES 1. The Register, 25 Aug 2026; TechCrunch, 25 Aug 2026; CNBC, 26 Aug 2026 (OpenAI "Jalapeño" inference benchmarks; Broadcom-built, TSMC N3P, HBM4; 1.5–1.9× throughput, 1.7–3.6× lower latency) — figures trace to SemiAnalysis, not independently measured; flagged. 2. NVIDIA Q2 FY2027 results (26 Aug 2026: US\$96.2bn, +106% y/y); CNBC — advancing MERIDIAN No. 86. 3. CNBC, 19 Aug 2026; Bloomberg, 7 Aug 2026 — third-country compute-access review (Thailand, Malaysia, Japan); running context.

THE HOME LAB • OPEN, WITH STRINGS

The Year's Biggest Open Model Drops Its Weights — Then Decides Who May Run Them

Zhipu released the full GLM-5.3 flagship this week, reversing the cyber-risk hold we flagged a fortnight ago. The weights are public; the licence is not the usual open one. Anyone big enough must ask permission first — and, for the home rig, the flagship was never the point. The model that matters on your own GPUs still fits under a genuinely open licence.

this story  

The wait is over, and it came with a clause. GLM-5.3 — 744 billion parameters, about forty billion active, a 200,000-token context — shipped its open weights on Friday, ending the hold Zhipu placed on the flagship over cyber-misuse fears (No. 86).¹ But the licence is not the MIT terms the lab's smaller models carry. Under the new "GLM-5.3 licence," any provider clearing ten billion US dollars of revenue over any twelve-month window must pass Zhipu's own security review before using it commercially — a gate aimed squarely at hyperscalers, and the first time the newest open model comes with a permission slip.

The cyber rationale is not invented: on one vulnerability-discovery benchmark the model posts a leading score, which is precisely the capability a bad

actor would want and the lab says it is guarding. Whether the licence is caution or commercial capture is the argument — because the only fully sanctioned way to run the very newest weights now routes through Zhipu's own API, at Zhipu's prices.

For the reader's rig, though, the flagship was always aspirational. At four-bit quantisation it still needs on the order of 445 gigabytes of memory — a data-centre box, "eight GPUs," not a study.² The model that actually matters at home is the one that shipped days earlier: GLM-5.3-Flash, a 320-billion-parameter mixture with a million-token context that fits in roughly 170 gigabytes at four-bit — reachable on a serious multi-GPU home lab — and, crucially, still under a plain MIT licence. The headline is the flagship; the home story is the Flash.

~445GB

MEMORY TO RUN THE GLM-5.3 FLAGSHIP AT FOUR-BIT — A DATA-CENTRE FOOTPRINT, NOT A DESK; THE HOME-RUNNABLE FLASH NEEDS ~170GB AND KEEPS ITS MIT LICENCE²

THE CHATTER • R/LOCALLLAMA

The board split cleanly. One camp reads the fortnight's delay as maturity — the prior generation stays MIT, so nobody is stranded, and a security review that only touches ten-billion-dollar firms leaves the hobbyist alone. The other reads a downgrade dressed as safety: for the first time the only legal way to run the newest model is the maker's own service.

r/LocalLLaMA; Hugging Face discussion — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • A GATE IS NOT A WEIGHT

Hold the "most powerful open model" headline to what it means at home: nothing, directly. A 445-gigabyte flagship is not self-hostable on any home rig, so the open-weights story is really an enterprise story — and the revenue-gated licence makes that explicit. The genuinely useful release is the Flash, which is open in the way that counts: you can download it, run it, and keep it. Read the licence, not the parameter count.

desk judgement; licence text

ON THE BENCH

The number that matters. Active parameters, not total — GLM-5.3's ~40B active is what sets the per-token compute, which is why a mixture model this large can be served at all.³

The practical rig. Flash at four-bit clears on a multi-card build; budget the VRAM first, the context window second.

The catch. A million-token context is a memory bill of its own — the headline length is rarely the length you can afford to keep live.

SOURCES 1. The New Stack; Hugging Face (zai-org/GLM-5.3) — GLM-5.3 flagship weights released 28 Aug 2026 (744B total / ~40B active, 200K context; new "GLM-5.3 licence" with a >US\$10bn-revenue security-review gate; leading vulnerability-discovery benchmark score) — advancing MERIDIAN No. 86. 2. kingy.ai; apidog — VRAM footprints (~445GB Q4 flagship / ~170GB Q4 Flash; "eight GPUs"); GLM-5.3-Flash (26 Aug 2026, MIT, 320B-A18B, 1M context). 3. Active-parameter versus total-parameter compute, and context-window memory scaling — kingy.ai; community benchmarks. Home-lab guidance is general, not a recommendation to purchase.

THE KIT · THE CAMERA THEY LEFT OUT

The Smart Glasses Whose Best Feature Is a Deletion

RayNeo's iO, on sale next week, is the cheapest glasses yet to put a real display in the lens — and it does it while deliberately leaving the camera off, betting that a HUD without a stranger's eye on you is the version people actually wear. At US\$479 it undercuts the field. The caveat is the one every always-on device carries.

this story  

The pitch is a subtraction. RayNeo's iO — announced on the twenty-first, on sale on the fourth of September — is a 33-gram pair of glasses with a monochrome green micro-LED display floating in the right lens, an AI assistant, and live translation across dozens of languages.¹ What it does not have is a camera. In a category defined by the camera — and by the social friction of pointing one at people — RayNeo has bet that the display is the part worth wearing and the lens is the part that draws the stare. It is the restraint-as-feature move, priced to make the point: US\$479, well under the display-equipped rivals.

The engineering serves the same idea. A four-microphone array and bone-conduction sensing handle voice; the waveguide is claimed to hit 1,300

US\$479

THE IO'S LAUNCH PRICE (US\$529 WITH THE CHARGING CASE) — THE CHEAPEST GLASSES YET WITH A REAL IN-LENS DISPLAY, AND 33 GRAMS ON THE NOSE¹

THE CHATTER · THE PREVIEW CIRCUIT

The hands-on write-ups cluster around the same surprise: the camera-free bet reads as a feature, not a compromise — less of the social stigma that has dogged camera glasses, at a price that undercuts the display-equipped field. The wariness is uniform too: a monochrome-green HUD is a limited canvas, and a 240-milliamp-hour cell is a small tank.

Engadget; TechRadar; Digital Trends; GSMArena — hands-on previews, characterised

nits so the HUD survives Singapore glare¹; a hardwired indicator light fires whenever it is recording, so the device cannot listen in silence. For a buy-once reader the appeal is a genuinely new capability — a heads-up display you can wear to lunch — at a price that does not assume you will replace it in a year.

Two honest caveats sit under the enthusiasm. The verdicts so far are hands-on previews, not lived-in reviews — nobody has carried a shipping unit through a week — and the battery is a modest 240 milliamp-hours, which the maker rates at up to two days of light use but far less if you lean on translation. Treat the first-week raves as first impressions, and wait for the second week.

THE SCEPTIC · CAMERA-FREE IS NOT DATA-FREE

Leaving the camera out removes the most visible privacy problem, not the deepest one. This is still an always-on, four-microphone, cloud-assisted device on your face, and RayNeo has said little about what it retains, how long, or how you delete it — an indicator light governs recording, not listening. The buy-once case also assumes firmware support outlives the fashion cycle, which no smart-glasses maker has yet proven.

privacy read; spec sheet — characterised

ALSO ON THE BENCH

The cinematic line. RayNeo also launched a pricier GT series aimed at big-screen media rather than a HUD — a different buyer. **The context.** The iO's rivals still pair a camera with audio and lean on the phone for a display; the iO's wager is that a real HUD, minus the lens, is the trade more people will make. **The wait.** IFA demos run through 8 September; full retail reviews should follow the on-sale date.²

SOURCES 1. PR Newswire, 21 Aug 2026 (RayNeo iO announcement; on sale 4 Sep 2026; US\$479 / US\$529 with case; 33g; camera-free; monochrome green micro-LED waveguide to ~1,300 nits; 4-mic array + bone conduction; 240mAh; live translation, on-board AI); GSMArena; TechPowerUp. 2. Engadget; TechRadar; Digital Trends; The Gadgeteer — hands-on previews, Aug 2026 (verdicts pre-launch, not full reviews); RayNeo GT/GT Max cinematic line launched alongside; IFA Berlin demos 4–8 Sep. The Kit hero is a representative image; see the caption.

THE GOOD LIFE · PROVENANCE ON THE WRIST

A Watch Built on a Fifty-Year-Old Movement, and Signed by the Hand That Saved It

Singer Reimagined's new chronograph does something the spec sheet cannot flatter: it takes a genuine, unused 1970s Valjoux 72 movement, restores and refinishes it to haute-horlogerie standard, and engraves the bridge "Restored by Singer." It is expensive, hand-wound and slow. It is also the weekend's clearest argument for the maker over the number.

this story  

The idea is close to heresy and entirely the point. Rather than build a new movement or buy a modern one, Singer Reimagined has gone hunting for new-old-stock Valjoux 72 chronograph calibres — the hand-wound engine that powered a generation of the great vintage chronographs — and restored them one at a time: stripped, refinished with frosted bridges and hand-polished bevels, then cased in a compact 38.8-millimetre watch with a glassbox sapphire front and back so you can watch the fifty-year-old machine work.¹ The Y-shaped chronograph bridge carries the tell of the whole enterprise, engraved "Restored by Singer." You are not buying a spec. You are buying a provenance and the hand that guaranteed it.

The numbers are unapologetic. The steel edition runs to fifty pieces at CHF 23,000 before tax; a

50

STEEL PIECES, AT CHF 23,000 BEFORE TAX, EACH BUILT ON A RESTORED 1970S VALJOUX 72; THE GOLD EDITION IS 20 PIECES AT CHF 45,000, DELIVERIES FROM NOVEMBER²

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE WATCH PRESS SAYS

The hands-on coverage lands warm. The vintage character of the case and dial draws praise, and the finishing is called superb; the bolder hands and logo nudge it just contemporary enough to read as a watch, not a museum piece. The recurring note is that this is a piece bought with the head and the heart in agreement about what it is — a restoration, celebrated as one.

Hodinkee; Monochrome; Fratello; Time+Tide — characterised

yellow-gold version, twenty pieces, is nearly double.² For that you get a 2.5-hertz, seventeen-jewel movement with about forty-four hours of reserve — figures a modern automatic beats without trying. That is the trade the watch asks you to make on purpose: the value is in the restoration and the finishing and the scarcity, not the rate.

It is a collector's object more than a daily one, and honest about it. The 38.8-millimetre case is genuinely wearable, the run is genuinely small, and the finishing has drawn real praise from the watch press. Whether that is worth haute-horlogerie money for a restored ébauche is the question the desk cannot answer for you — only frame. If provenance is the thing you value, this is provenance made literal, and signed.

THE SCEPTIC · HAUTE-HORLOGERIE MONEY FOR VINTAGE MECHANICS

Say the trade plainly. You are paying CHF 23,000-plus for a restored 1970s ébauche — hand-wound, 2.5 hertz, forty-four hours — that a four-figure modern chronograph outperforms on every spec that can be measured. The value rests entirely on the story and the finishing being worth it to you. That is a legitimate thing to buy; it is not a thing the spec sheet defends, and anyone selling it as "an investment" is selling the story twice.

desk judgement; spec comparison

ALSO IN THE CASE

The Bond tie-in. Omega's first chronograph in the Seamaster Diver 300M line, a "First Light" tie-in to the 007 video game, arrived earlier in the year at about US\$9,400 — 44mm, not limited, a fan buy more than a collector one.³ **The contrast.** Set the two side by side and the desk's thesis holds: one sells a marketing partnership, the other sells a movement it saved by hand. General guidance, not investment advice.

SOURCES 1. Singer Reimagined (Heritage V72; restored NOS Valjoux 72, 17 jewels, 18,000 vph/2.5Hz, ~44h reserve; 38.8mm, glassbox sapphire, "Restored by Singer" bridge); Hodinkee; Monochrome — unveiled 29 Jul 2026, pre-orders live, deliveries from Nov 2026. 2. Monochrome; Time+Tide; Collective Horology (steel SR621, CHF 23,000 ex-tax, 50 pieces; gold SR620-1, CHF 45,000 ex-tax, 20 pieces). 3. Omega (Seamaster Diver 300M Chronograph "007 First Light," ref. 210.32.44.51.01.002, ~US\$9,400, 44mm, cal. 9900, non-limited). The Good Life hero is a representative image; see the caption. General guidance, not investment advice.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE FILM THEY TRIED TO ERASE

The Cartoon a Studio Wrote Off for a Tax Break Finally Reaches a Screen

"Coyote vs. Acme" was finished, shelved for a write-down, and nearly deleted for good. Three years and one public campaign later, a small distributor has put it in cinemas this weekend — to a modest opening and unmistakably fond reviews. The box office is the footnote; that it survived at all is the point.

this story  

The striking thing about "Coyote vs. Acme" is that you can watch it at all. The live-action-and-animation hybrid — Wile E. Coyote suing the company whose gadgets keep failing him, with a human lawyer in his corner — was completed, then shelved by its studio in 2023 as a tax write-off, the film itself treated as worth more deleted than released.¹ A public campaign and an independent distributor pulled it back from the ledger; this weekend it opened in cinemas, roughly three years late.

The reception is the reward. Critics have it certified fresh in the mid-nineties, audiences warmer still, and the cast — a put-upon lawyer, an oily opposing

counsel — has drawn the kind of word of mouth a shelved film is not supposed to earn.² The opening weekend is modest, a third-place low-double-digit-millions figure on Saturday estimates, against a reported budget many times that. On the studio's spreadsheet it is not a hit. On every other measure it is a rescue.

Which is the point worth keeping. A finished piece of work was nearly unmade by an accounting decision, and the people who wanted it made brought it back — a small, cheerful cousin of the weekend's larger thread about the hand behind the thing, and about who gets to decide whether the thing survives.

~95%

THE CRITICS' FRESH SCORE ON RELEASE — FOR A FILM ITS OWN STUDIO VALUED MORE AS A WRITE-OFF THAN A RELEASE; OPENING WEEKEND A MODEST THIRD PLACE ON SATURDAY ESTIMATES²

THE CHATTER · CRITICS & FANS

The consensus is affectionate rather than ecstatic — a genuinely funny, well-made family film that over-performs the low expectations a three-year shelving created. The fan framing is louder than the numbers: this is being told as a win for the people who refused to let it disappear, which colours every review in its favour.

Rotten Tomatoes; Metacritic; TheWrap — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · A RESCUE IS NOT A BLOCKBUSTER

Keep the victory the right size. A low-double-digit-millions open on a film made for many times that is a symbolic and public-relations win, not a commercial one — the story is "the fans won," not "the box office won," and the record-breaking headlines attach to a narrow, qualified record. Saturday's figures are estimates; wait for the actuals before carving any of it in stone.

Deadline; Box Office Mojo — figures preliminary, flagged

ON THE TURNTABLE

The chart. The week's biggest story on the album chart is a global girl group taking its first number one — a young-skewing pop win worth noting more than dwelling on.³ **For the rest of us.** New records landed the same week from Interpol, Mastodon and The Warning — the grown-up guitar shelf, quietly restocked. Reception is early; treat first-week takes as first-week takes.

SOURCES 1. Deadline; Cartoon Brew — "Coyote vs. Acme" (shelved 2023 for a tax write-off; sold to Ketchup Entertainment; theatrical release weekend of 28–30 Aug 2026); dir. Dave Green; Will Forte, John Cena, Lana Condor. 2. Rotten Tomatoes (~95% Certified Fresh); Metacritic (77); Deadline (Thu previews ~US\$1.7m; 3-day estimate ~US\$14m, #3) — Saturday estimates, confirm actuals. 3. Billboard (girl-group EP debuts at No. 1, chart dated 29 Aug 2026) — single-sourced, flagged; Official Charts / new-release lists (Interpol, Mastodon, The Warning, ~28 Aug 2026).

THE FAMILY DESK · TWELVE, AND THE PHONE IN THE LOCKER

The Study Says Guard the Sleep, Not the Screen-Minutes

A large new analysis links heavy screen use in children to worse mental health — but its own finding is that the damage runs through sleep and inactivity, which is where a parent can actually act. It lands the same term Singapore's schools put phones away. For a twelve-year-old starting secondary one, the useful response is a routine, not a panic.

this story  

The headline number is alarming and the mechanism is reassuring. A study of more than fifty thousand American children and adolescents found that those with four or more hours of daily screen time carried markedly higher odds of anxiety and depression — on the order of forty-five and sixty per cent higher — than lighter users.¹ But the same analysis identifies *why*: physical activity and sleep are the parallel channels through which the harm travels. Screens displace movement and bedtime, and it is the lost movement and bedtime that do much of the damage.

That is the useful part, because sleep and activity are levers a parent can pull without a fight about the device itself. Protect the hours — a consistent

bedtime, phones out of the bedroom, a daily block of real movement — and you have addressed the pathway the data actually implicates, rather than staging a losing war over minutes. For a child starting secondary one, whose sleep is about to meet an earlier bell, the bedtime is the battle worth choosing.

The timing is apt. From January this year Singapore's secondary schools require students to keep smartphones and smartwatches stowed outside lesson time — recess, CCAs and remedial included — so the school day already does some of the work.² The health guidance runs alongside it: for this age band, keep non-schoolwork screen time modest, and treat the weekend, when a quarter of teens run well past four hours, as the real test.

Protect the sleep and the movement, and you have addressed the pathway the data actually implicates.

+61%

THE HIGHER ODDS OF DEPRESSION ASSOCIATED WITH FOUR-PLUS HOURS OF DAILY SCREEN TIME IN THE STUDY — BUT SLEEP AND PHYSICAL ACTIVITY ARE THE MEDIATORS, I.E. THE LEVERS¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT PARENTS REPORT

A survey doing the rounds this summer put a number on the parental cost — mothers and fathers losing hours of sleep a week to worry about their children's screen habits, with self-esteem and social media topping the list. It is commissioned sentiment, not evidence, but it captures the mood the research is landing into: anxious, and hungry for something to actually do.

Talker Research survey (commissioned), Jul 2026 — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST

Read the ceiling on the claim. The headline study is cross-sectional and parent-reported on pandemic-era data, which means it shows correlation, not cause — and the arrow may run the other way, with anxious children retreating to screens. The larger research camp holds that average screen-time effects on wellbeing are small, and that what a child does online, and the vulnerabilities they bring to it, matter more than the raw hours. Protect sleep and movement; skip the minute-counting panic.

Orben; Odgers — research consensus, characterised

THE PRACTICAL LINE

Bedtime first. A fixed lights-out and no phone in the bedroom protects the mediator the data implicates.

Movement daily. A real activity block is the other channel — and it competes with the screen for the same hour. **Content over clock.** What and where beats how-long: co-view, keep the phone in shared space, and know the apps. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1. "Excessive screen time is associated with mental health problems in US children and adolescents: physical activity and sleep as parallel mediators," *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* (Nature portfolio), Jan 2026 (n=50,231, NSCH 2020–21; ≥4h/day: anxiety aOR ~1.45, depression aOR ~1.65). 2. Ministry of Education, Singapore (secondary students to stow phones/smartwatches outside lesson time from Jan 2026; MOE release 30 Nov 2025); Ministry of Health screen-use guidance (Jan 2026). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE HANDOVER AGE

Coaching a Twelve-Year-Old Through the Year the Independence Starts

Secondary one is a handover: more autonomy, a longer commute, a wider social world, and a phone that is now part of all three. The research points the same way as common sense — widen the leash deliberately, keep the conversation open, and let the school's rules do the enforcing so home can stay the safe place.

The move to secondary school is the year the scaffolding starts coming down on purpose. A twelve-year-old is asked to manage a timetable, a commute, money and a widening set of friendships more or less at once — and the phone is now the tool for all of them, which is exactly why a blanket ban at home tends to backfire. The evidence-informed posture is graduated trust: expand independence in named steps, attach each to a responsibility, and keep the channel open for when it goes wrong, because it will.

The comfort in the term's change is that the enforcement has moved off the parent. With phones stowed through the school day, home no longer has

to be the sole rule-maker; it can be the place the rules are discussed rather than imposed. That distinction matters more at twelve than at ten — early adolescence is a sensitive window for autonomy and identity, and a parent who polices every minute forfeits the influence they will want later.

None of which is a licence for absence. The practical middle is a coach's, not a warden's: know the apps and the friends, keep the device in shared space overnight, model the behaviour you are asking for, and treat the first slip as information rather than betrayal. The goal for the year is not a controlled child but a competent one.

THE CHATTER · THE PARENT GROUPS

On local parenting forums the term's phone rules landed mostly welcomed — relief that the school would carry the enforcement, tempered by the familiar worry about the after-school hours and the group chats that never close. The recurring practical tip is a shared-space charging station: phones sleep in the kitchen, not the bedroom.

local parenting groups; Grow Well SG materials — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · A BAN IS NOT A SKILL

Guardrails buy time; they do not teach judgement. A child whose phone use is only ever restricted, never coached, arrives at unsupervised access — which comes — without the habits to handle it. Use the structure the school now provides to practise the harder thing: talking about what they see, agreeing limits together, and letting small mistakes happen while the stakes are still low. The aim is a competent user, not a compliant one.

developmental guidance — characterised; general, not medical advice

~2h

THE RECOMMENDED DAILY CEILING FOR NON-SCHOOLWORK SCREEN TIME AT THIS AGE BAND UNDER THE CURRENT HEALTH GUIDANCE — WITH THE WEEKEND, NOT THE SCHOOL DAY, THE REAL TEST¹

FOR THE YEAR AHEAD

Sleep is the keystone. An earlier school start plus a phone in the room is the combination to break first. **Widen deliberately.** Name the new freedoms — the solo commute, the later curfew — and pair each with a check-in. **Stay curious.** Ask what they are watching and playing before you rule on it; the knowing is the influence. General guidance, not medical or psychological advice.

SOURCES 1. Ministry of Health, Singapore — screen-use guidance for children and adolescents (Jan 2026); Grow Well SG digital-parenting resources (MDDI/MSF, 2025–26); developmental-psychology guidance on early-adolescent autonomy, characterised. Family content is general guidance, not medical, psychological or legal advice.

THE MACRO DESK • THE RATE RISE COMES BACK

A Market Spends the Weekend Pricing a Hike the Fed Had All but Retired

A hawkish new chair and a hot inflation print have done something the year did not expect: turned September into a coin-flip between a hold and a rate rise. The dollar and front-end yields firmed into the close; gold, improbably, held near its record anyway. The through-line for a global portfolio is a regime that is getting less friendly, not more.

this story  

VWRA	US 10Y	DXY	GOLD	BITCOIN	BRENT
~\$195 ▲	~4.72% ▲	~99.7 ▲	~\$4,600	~\$80k ▼	~\$88 ▼

The repricing dominated the weekend, and it ran one way. A hawkish keynote from the new Fed chair — "work to do" on inflation — collided with a hot July inflation print, and the market swung from expecting a September hold or cut to a coin-flip on an outright rate rise, hike odds climbing toward the mid-fifties.¹ The core inflation gauge sat above three per cent, still part oil-inflected by the Hormuz premium (p3). Higher-for-longer became a live tail, not a slogan.

Follow the chain. A firmer rate path lifts front-end yields and the dollar — both firmed into Friday's close — a headwind for long-duration equities and a drag on global-bond prices. It should weigh on gold too; instead the metal held within a whisker of its record even as the dollar rose, a sign the haven and central-bank bid is, for now, outmuscling the real-yield gravity that usually pulls it down.² Bitcoin, meanwhile, sagged toward eighty thousand as liquidity tightened — the high-beta risk read against gold's hedge read. Same force, two prices. Explanation, not advice.

~56%

THE MARKET-IMPLIED ODDS OF A SEPTEMBER RATE HIKE AFTER THE KEYNOTE AND A HOT INFLATION PRINT — UP FROM ROUGHLY ONE-IN-THREE A DAY EARLIER, A HOLD NO LONGER THE BASE CASE¹

SEPTEMBER: FROM HOLD TO HIKE

Before the keynote
~70% no change

After the keynote + hot PCE
~56% a 25bp HIKE

The market flipped from pricing a hold/cut to a coin-flip on a

A Meridian original. Source: CME FedWatch implied odds, ~28 Aug 2026. Explanation, not advice.

THE CHATTER • WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

The regime read is dollar-bid, higher-for-longer, risk-off at the margin. That is a mild headwind for a global all-world equity position and a price drag on global bonds as yields firm; gold is the standout, holding near records on haven and central-bank demand even against a rising dollar; bitcoin is trading as the liquidity-sensitive risk asset, giving ground as the cut narrative fades.

desk read — explanation, not advice

THE SCEPTIC • ODDS ARE NOT OUTCOMES

A coin-flip is still a coin-flip. Implied odds move on a single speech and a single data point and can round-trip just as fast on the next; the Fed has not hiked, and a firm dollar has been called for months without arriving. Treat the regime label as a description of pressure, not a prediction — and remember gold holding against a rising dollar is precisely the kind of anomaly that resolves suddenly in one direction or the other.

desk judgement; rate-path caveats

THE LEVELS, IN BRIEF

Rates & dollar. US 10-year ~4.72%, firmer; DXY ~99.7. **Havens & risk.** Gold ~US\$4,600, near its 24 Aug record; bitcoin ~US\$80k, softer. **Growth & oil.** Global equities held on the week; Brent ~US\$88, easing on the Omani-corridor headlines. Levels around the US close, Fri 28 Aug; never a fabricated print — where a number can't be verified it is held.²

SOURCES 1. CNBC, 28 Aug 2026 (September decision a "coin flip" as hike odds rose ~56%); Coindesk (Warsh Jackson Hole keynote, "work to do"); CBS News, 26 Aug 2026 (July PCE ~3.7% headline / ~3.3% core). 2. TradingEconomics; USAGOLD; Fortune; Barchart — levels around the US close, Fri 28 Aug 2026 (VWRA ~US\$195; US 10Y ~4.72%; DXY ~99.7; gold ~US\$4,600 near a 24 Aug record ~US\$4,712; bitcoin ~US\$80k; Brent ~US\$88). The Macro Desk is market explanation and education, not investment advice; forecasts are flagged as forecasts.

THE RABBIT HOLE • FPV DRONES

The One Flying Machine You Build Yourself, and Fly from Inside

A camera drone flies itself; an FPV quad is flown — no self-levelling, no hover, a live feed piped into goggles so you sit in the cockpit. It is the corner of droning where people still solder their own aircraft, argue about firmware, and crash on purpose to learn. This weekend we go down it: the gear, the money pit, and the hard truth about flying it in Singapore.

this story  

Begin with the distinction that defines the hobby. A DJI Mavic is a flying camera: GPS-locked, self-hovering, it returns home at the tap of a button and forgives everything. An FPV — first-person-view — quad in its true "acro" mode does none of that. There is no self-levelling and no hover; the throttle is raw motor thrust, so the machine drops the instant you stop flying it, and you fly it not by watching a screen but by wearing goggles fed a live camera stream from the aircraft's nose.¹ You are, in every sense that matters, inside it. That is the gateway drug and the skill ceiling at once.

The world divides into three tempers. Racing runs sub-250-gram to five-inch machines through gates on the lowest-latency video money can buy, organised into leagues that have logged tens of

~\$1.5B

THE FPV-DRONE MARKET, 2025, GROWING AT A DOUBLE-DIGIT CLIP ON MOST ESTIMATES — A NICHE WITH REAL SCALE, THOUGH THE FORECASTS DIVERGE WIDELY BY FIRM²

THE CHATTER • THE GATEWAY MOMENT

Ask where anyone started and two answers repeat: the DJI Avata bundle — "the gateway to FPV," safe and easy enough to hook you — and, right after, the first time they switched a simulator into acro mode and discovered manual flight is a genuine skill, not a setting. The first is the on-ramp; the second is the reason people stay.

[r/fpv](#); [DigitalCameraWorld reviews](#) — characterised

thousands of heats.² Freestyle is the acrobatic, proximity-flying, footage-making strand — the one that fills the feeds. Cinematic and long-range is the calmer end: prop-guarded "cinewhoops" indoors, seven-to-ten-inch cruisers with GPS rescue for the horizon. Different tribes, one control layout.

It is a real and growing world — a market put around one-and-a-half billion dollars, a racing league with tens of thousands of members across hundreds of chapters — even as the enthusiast middle grumbles that the consumer giant is eating it.² The next two pages are the descent: where the community lives, what the gear actually costs, what is genuinely new, and why, in Singapore, most of this happens indoors or not at all.

THE SCEPTIC • "THE HOBBY IS DYING"

It is the community's favourite lament, and it is half true. The overall market is growing, but the growth is the consumer, ready-to-fly end; the do-it-yourself hobby-shop middle — the solder-your-own culture that gave the hobby its soul — is genuinely squeezed as one giant standardises the parts. The hobby is not dying. The version of it that required you to build is getting optional.

[YouTube "state of FPV" commentary](#) — characterised, sentiment

THE MAP OF THE DESCENT

Page two. The community — where the arguments and the guides live — and the gear, tier by tier, from the box-set whoop to the built-by-hand five-inch. **Page three.** What is genuinely new in the last year, the custom bench, the real economics, the honest first ninety days, and the Singapore rules that decide whether you can fly any of it at all.

SOURCES 1. UAVCoach; DigitalCameraWorld; Oscar Liang (FPV vs camera drones; acro mode has no self-levelling or GPS hover; goggles fed a live nose-camera feed). 2. MultiGP (racing league ~38,500 members, 385 chapters, 16,000+ races since 2015); Maximize / Growth Market Reports (FPV market ~US\$1.5bn 2025, double-digit CAGR, estimates diverge) — flagged as a range.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE COMMUNITY & THE GEAR

Where the Arguments Live, and What the Kit Really Costs

The community is a written culture — long-form guides, firmware threads, one methodical YouTuber telling you to "get it dialled in." The gear is a ladder from a hundred-dollar box-set to a build you solder yourself, and, for a buy-once reader, the honest advice is to spend on the two things that outlast every quad: the radio and the goggles.

The gathering places sort by temperament. The big general hub is a subreddit where beginners post build-checks and crash clips and the two eternal arguments run — the consumer giant against "the soul of the hobby," analog nostalgia against digital.¹ A classic long-form forum is where firmware releases break first, patient and technical. One written reference — Oscar Liang's guides — is the standard everyone links, and one YouTuber, Joshua Bardwell, has built a following of a few hundred thousand on the single promise of helping you "get your FPV dialled in." The racing league supplies the competitive spine, with chapters and spec classes worldwide.

The gear ladder starts cheap and gets deliberate. The disposable tier is a hundred-to-two-hundred-dollar box-set — a tiny indoor "whoop" with goggles and radio thrown in — to learn on and outgrow.² Above it,

~\$500–900

A SERIOUS FIVE-INCH SETUP ALL-IN — QUAD, GOGGLES AND RADIO — WHETHER BOUGHT BIND-AND-FLY OR SELF-BUILT; GOGGLES ALONE RUN US\$229–699²

THE CHATTER • WHAT OWNERS ACTUALLY SAY

The value verdict is near-unanimous: the iFlight and GEPRC bind-and-fly quads fly well out of the box and are the sane starting build, with the caveat that factory solder and tune can be hit-or-miss, so a first check-over pays for itself. On the video side, the consensus "endgame" is now the newest digital air unit — right up until the next one ships, which is the running joke and the running cost.

r/fpv; GetFPV / RaceDayQuads owner threads — characterised

the ready-to-fly path splits: the consumer route (a DJI Avata or the palm-sized Neo, safe and heavily discounted) or a "bind-and-fly" freestyle quad from iFlight or GEPRC, roughly four to nine hundred dollars, that flies out of the box with the current high-definition air unit already fitted. The build-your-own route is the hobby's heart: a flight-controller stack running open-source Betaflight firmware, motors and a frame you choose, soldered together over an evening.

For a buy-once reader the counsel is specific: the quad is a consumable, so spend where it lasts. The radio and the goggles survive every crash and every rebuild, so buy those once and well — a good multi-protocol transmitter, and a goggle you can live behind — and treat frames, motors and props as the running cost they are.³

THE SCEPTIC • BUY THE RADIO, NOT THE HYPE

The trap for a buy-once buyer is treating the aircraft as the purchase. It is the opposite: the quad is the thing you will destroy, repeatedly and on purpose. The money that actually compounds goes into the control link and the goggles — the parts that transfer to every future build. Everything strapped to the frame is a consumable priced to be replaced, and the market is designed to sell you the next one.

buy-once read; community consensus — characterised

THE KIT, BY LAYER

Radio (buy once). A RadioMaster Boxer or full-size TX16S, running the open ExpressLRS link that has become the de-facto standard. **Goggles (buy once).** DJI Goggles 3 or the budget N3; Walksnail for openness; HDZero for the racers' fixed low latency. **Quad (consumable).** A GEPRC or iFlight bind-and-fly to start; a Betaflight self-build when you want to solder. **Frame that lasts.** Armattan carries a transferable lifetime warranty — the one buy-once part on the aircraft itself.³

SOURCES 1. r/fpv; IntoFPV; Oscar Liang (oscarliang.com); Joshua Bardwell (YouTube, ~306k subscribers, Jul 2026); MultiGP — community map, characterised. 2. BetaFPV (Cetus box-sets ~US\$150–200); GetFPV / RaceDayQuads (iFlight Nazgul, GEPRC MARK5/Cinelog bind-and-fly ~US\$400–930 with the DJI O4 air unit); DJI (Avata 2, Neo 2). 3. RadioMaster (Boxer ELRS ~US\$140, TX16S); DJI Goggles 3 (~US\$499) / N3 (~US\$229); Walksnail; HDZero; Armattan (transferable lifetime frame warranty). Prices indicative, Aug 2026.

THE RABBIT HOLE · WHAT'S NEW, AND HOW TO START

A Year of Real Steps Forward — and Why, in Singapore, You Fly Indoors

The last twelve months brought genuine advances, not just new box art: a higher-definition air unit, a control link that finally speaks the long-range protocol natively, a palm-sized drone with all-round sensing. The starter path is sim-first and cheap. The catch, on this island, is the law — and it points most flying into a gym.

Start with what actually changed. DJI's newest air unit brought a real jump in image quality and range and is now the default high-definition build; the open ExpressLRS control link reached version four, bringing mainstream GPS-rescue and long-range flying; and a palm-sized Neo 2 added all-round sensing to a 150-gram machine — a big deal for camera users, a smaller one for hardcore pilots.¹ Real advances, the community agrees, not launch hype — though not all of them for everyone.²

THE RUNNING COST

Sim + radio to start	~\$85-160
Serious 5" + goggles	~\$500-900
Consumables / year	~\$100-300

Props \$2-5/set · motors \$15-25 · packs \$25-45.
One racer logged ~\$4,800 over three years — about

A Meridian original. Sources: DroneNestle; FPV Drone Guide, 2026 — indicative.

THE CHATTER · THE JARGON YOU'LL HIT

A field glossary: *acro* (manual, no self-level); *BNF* (bind-and-fly); *Betaflight* (the open firmware); *ELRS* (the control link); *whoop* (a tiny indoor quad); *smoke-stopper* (the fuse that saves a bad solder); *dial it in* (tune it). Learn six and the forums stop reading as a foreign language.

community glossary — characterised

Then the hard part, which is legal, not technical. In Singapore any aircraft over 250 grams must be registered; outdoor flight is capped low and barred within five kilometres of any airfield — much of the island — and flying under goggles legally needs a spotter.³ The realistic path here is a sub-250-gram machine, flown indoors and at the club fields, with a simulator doing the early learning — the twenty-dollar sim that saves hundreds in crashed hardware. Check the no-fly map before every flight.

THE SCEPTIC · THE ENDGAME IS A MYTH

The community admits it when pressed: FPV is a subscription of parts and power. Things wear out by design, each new air unit or link version manufactures real pressure to re-buy, and the "endgame build" never arrives because a better one always ships. Budget a hundred to three hundred dollars a year in consumables at minimum, expect to fix what you fly, and buy the skill — which is the only part that compounds — before the gear.

DroneNestle; FPV Drone Guide — characterised

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Weeks 1-4. A real radio (~US\$65) into a simulator (~US\$20).
Weeks 4-8. A tiny indoor whoop, sub-250g, no registration.
Weeks 8-12. A bind-and-fly five-inch and goggles — or your first solder. **Always.** Register anything over 250g and fly goggles with a spotter.³

NEXT DESCENTS · YOU PICK TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Tenkara — fly fishing with a fixed line and no reel: mountain-stream minimalism with a deep tackle culture.

Home mixology — the home bar as craft: clear ice, Japanese tools, and the gear that changes the drink.

Vinyl & turntables — the analog revival next to the hi-fi: pressing quality, the cartridge rabbit hole, crate-digging.

SOURCES 1. DJI (O4 Air Unit / O4 Air Unit Pro, announced 9 Jan 2025; DJI Neo 2, 13 Nov 2025); GitHub/ExpressLRS (v4.0, 2025, native MAVLink) — community verdicts characterised. 2. Steam (Liftoff ~US\$20, VelociDrone, Uncrashed); BetaFPV (Cetus whoop box-set); starter-path guidance, Oscar Liang / community. 3. CAAS Singapore (UA >250g must be registered; ~60m height cap without permit; no-fly within 5km of airfields; FPV goggles require a spotter) — verify on caas.gov.sg before flying; regs current as of Aug 2026, flagged.

FITNESS • THE EFFICIENT SPRINT

Fewer All-Out Repeats Buy the Same Lungs — the Study, and the Catch

A new meta-analysis finds that piling on sprint repetitions doesn't add to the aerobic payoff: a low-rep session lifts VO2 max about as much as a punishing one. For a time-pressed mid-40s optimiser that is genuinely good news — provided you read who was measured, and hear out the doctor who says the protocol obsession misses the point.

this story  

The finding is the kind an efficient person wants to hear. Pooling the sprint-interval-training studies, a July meta-analysis reports that the number of all-out sprint repetitions in a session does not moderate the improvement in VO2 max — the aerobic gain held even after the outlier studies were stripped out.¹ Translated: a short session of a few maximal efforts buys about the same top-end fitness as a longer, more brutal one. If VO2 max is what you are after, more suffering is not the price.

It matters because VO2 max is the metric the longevity crowd has settled on — a strong, dose-responsive predictor of all-cause mortality, with the largest gains coming from dragging the least-fit up

~5 yrs

THE LONGER LIFE A LARGE STUDY ASSOCIATED WITH TOP-TIER MIDLIFE FITNESS VERSUS THE LEAST FIT — THE REASON VO2 MAX, NOT SPRINT COUNT, IS THE NUMBER WORTH MOVING²

THE CHATTER • THE LONGEVITY FEEDS

In the optimiser discourse VO2 max is treated as the master metric, and time-efficiency is its own virtue — which is why "fewer reps, same aerobic gain" travels fast. The healthy pushback is that a group average is not a training plan, and that consistency over months, not the perfect session, is what actually moves the number for a real person.

longevity/optimiser commentary — characterised

toward the middle of the pack.² A time-efficient way to move that number is worth having when the calendar is the binding constraint. The protocol writes itself onto a busy week: one short, hard session on top of an easy aerobic base.

Read the caveats before you sprint, though. These meta-analyses lean on younger, already-active subjects over short windows, so "fewer reps, same gain" is an average of the trained and willing, not a promise for a deconditioned forty-five-year-old — and the untrained gain fastest anyway. All-out sprinting is also genuinely unpleasant and carries real cardiac cautions at this age; if you have been sedentary or carry risk, see a doctor before you red-line. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE SCEPTIC • THE PROTOCOL ISN'T THE POINT

A Singapore GP writing on longevity makes the useful correction: the crowd over-indexes on protocol minutiae — sprint counts, zone boundaries — when adherence is the variable that actually decides outcomes.³ All-out sprinting is unpleasant and skippable; an easy aerobic base you will actually keep doing beats a perfect interval session you quit in a month. Do the sprints if you enjoy them; do the base regardless.

Dr Samuel Choudhury (SG GP), May 2026 — characterised; not medical advice

TRY IT THIS WAY

The base. Keep the easy aerobic volume — it is the part that compounds and the part you will sustain. **The top-end.** Add one short session of a few all-out efforts a week; the study says you needn't pile on more. **The gate.** See a doctor first if you have been sedentary or carry cardiac risk — the caution is the point of "all-out." General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1. Hutchinson et al., "Number of Sprint Repetitions in a Sprint Interval Training Session Does Not Moderate Improvements in VO2max," *Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports*, Jul 2026 (doi 10.1111/sms.70347). 2. Cooper Center Longitudinal Study (>122,000; fitness-mortality dose-response); JACC 46-year follow-up (highest-fitness midlifera ~5 years longer) — older context, flagged. 3. Dr Samuel Choudhury (drsamuelgp.com), "Zone 2 Isn't the Longevity Magic Bullet," May 2026 — sceptic, characterised. Fitness content is general guidance, not medical advice.

THE TRAVEL DESK • WHAT CHANGED

Japan Flips Its Tax-Free Rules at the Till, and the Points Get Pricier

The headline for a Singapore flyer this season is a paperwork change with real money in it: from November, Japan's tax-free shopping moves to pay-first, refund-at-the-airport. Add a tripled departure tax, a dearer KrisFlyer chart, and a new satellite gate at Changi, and the ground rules for the autumn trip have quietly moved.

this story  

The change most likely to catch a shopper is procedural. From 1 November, Japan scraps its in-store tax exemption for the pay-first model: you pay the full tax-inclusive price at the register, then claim the consumption-tax refund at a terminal in the departure lobby, before check-in, within ninety days of purchase.¹ The sealed-bag rule and the general-versus-consumable split are gone, which simplifies the buying; the catch is cash-flow and a queue at the airport you did not have before. Pair it with the departure "sayonara" tax, tripled to three thousand yen since July, and the soft-yen bargain carries two new frictions.

The loyalty maths moved too. KrisFlyer's award rates rose five to twenty per cent late last year — the first change in over three years — and the newer

dynamic-award option has already crept up again; pre-devaluation saver seats remain bookable for travel into late October, which makes the next eight weeks the window to lock long-haul redemptions.² On the metal, Singapore Airlines is adding routes rather than cutting the network its schedule-readers feared, and United has put its upgraded business cabin on every San Francisco rotation.

At home, Changi opened a new satellite pier that gives aerobridge access to stands that used to mean an apron bus, and the long build toward Terminal 5 and the cross-island people-mover ground on in the background.³ The five-minute Johor rail link stays on track for a year-end target, with no fresh testing milestone to report this cycle — carried, as ever, as a promise until it is a platform.

¥3,000

JAPAN'S DEPARTURE TAX, TRIPLED FROM ¥1,000 SINCE 1 JULY; AND FROM 1 NOV TAX-FREE SHOPPING BECOMES PAY-FIRST, REFUND-AT-THE-AIRPORT WITHIN 90 DAYS¹

THE CHATTER • THE REFUND QUEUE NOBODY COSTED

Frequent-flyer boards read the tax-free flip as a net negative for the casual shopper and a wash for the disciplined one: you lose the instant discount and gain an airport errand, so the advice hardening online is to consolidate purchases, keep receipts tidy, and budget the extra half-hour at the terminal — or skip the refund on small buys entirely.

FlyerTalk; The MileLion — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • READ THE SCHEDULE, NOT THE SCARE

Take the alarming route-cut headlines with salt. A carrier's seasonal timetable trims and adds constantly, and a "sixteen destinations cut" line is usually a schedule read, not a strategy reversal — verify against the actual network before rebooking. Likewise, "record" airport-capacity milestones are a decade out; the thing that changes your trip this month is the refund queue, not Terminal 5.

schedule caveat; carrier network data — flagged

ENTRY RULES

POINTS

LOUNGE

ON THE BOARD

New route. Scoot begins Singapore–Guiyang from 26 Oct, three times weekly. **Cabin.** United's upgraded business is now on every Singapore–San Francisco flight. **Region.** Scoot's Okinawa and Labuan Bajo services (filling the Jetstar Asia gap) run on; Broome and Wuxi stay unreplaced.⁴

SOURCES 1. japan-guide.com; JNTO — Japan tax-free reform (pay-first, refund-at-airport from 1 Nov 2026; ¥5,000 minimum per store/day retained); Japan departure tax ¥3,000 from 1 Jul 2026. 2. Mainly Miles (Aug 2025); The MileLion (Mar 2026) — KrisFlyer award increase +5–20% (Nov 2025) and dynamic-award creep; pre-devaluation saver bookable to ~21 Oct 2026. 3. Changi Airport Group; LTA (new satellite pier, Aug 2026; T5 and people-mover progress). 4. Scoot / Time Out SG (SIN–Guiyang from 26 Oct 2026); travelandtourworld (United Polaris SIN–SFO, Aug 2026); Mothership (Scoot Okinawa/Labuan Bajo). RTS Link ~5-min crossing, year-end target — no fresh testing delta this cycle, flagged.

THE TRAVEL DESK · THE REST OF THE BOARD

Hotels for the Islands, a Refund Rehearsal, and the Long Builds

The developments that don't need a headline but change a plan: two design-led openings that pair with this weekend's Grand Tour, the entry-rule timetable for Europe, and the infrastructure that is still years from a ribbon.

Two openings ride straight into the Grand Tour. In the Seto Inland Sea, a trio of architect-designed villas opened this spring on a small island, and a spa hotel opened on Shodoshima in March — both aimed at the traveller who wants the art islands without the day-tripper churn, and both a reminder that the region is being built up for exactly the overnight stay this weekend's deep dive argues for (p21).¹ They are not cheap, and they are not meant to be.

On entry rules, Europe's timetable is the one to diary: the new Entry/Exit checks are live at the external border, while the paid ETIAS authorisation has slipped to 2027 — so a European trip this year needs the biometric queue but not yet the online permit.² For Japan, the tax and refund changes on the

previous page are the live ones; nothing else in the entry regime has moved this cycle.

And the long builds keep grinding without a ribbon to cut: Terminal 5's people-mover, the cross-island rail interchange, the Johor link's year-end target. None is a booking this season; all are worth tracking, because each one, when it lands, rewrites a routing the reader actually uses.

One line on the board is worth acting on now. KrisFlyer's pre-devaluation saver awards remain bookable only for travel into late October (p19), so the next eight weeks are the window to lock any long-haul redemption before the dearer dynamic chart takes fuller hold. Routes, cabins and gates add convenience; a points change quietly subtracts value, which is the one to diary.

The new hotels are selling the one thing the art islands are short of: quiet.

2027

THE YEAR EUROPE'S PAID TRAVEL PERMIT NOW LANDS; THE BIOMETRIC BORDER CHECKS ARE ALREADY LIVE, SO A TRIP THIS YEAR NEEDS THE QUEUE, NOT THE PERMIT

THE CHATTER · THE OVERNIGHT CASE

The forums that cover the art islands have converged on the same advice these new hotels are built around: stay the night. Day-trippers get the crowded midday version of everything; the traveller who sleeps on the island gets the pumpkin at dawn and the museums after the last ferry leaves. The new rooms are pricey, but they are selling the one thing the region is short of — quiet.

r/JapanTravel; Setouchi trip reports — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · AN OPENING IS NOT AN ITINERARY

A design hotel makes a trip photogenic, not necessarily better. The art islands reward planning around closed days and ferry times far more than around thread-count; a beautiful room on the wrong island, on a Monday when the museums shut, is a wasted night. Book the art first and the bed second — the reverse of how these openings are marketed.

desk judgement; Benesse Art Site calendar

IN BRIEF · DEPARTURES

Hotels. New architect-villa and spa openings across the Seto islands (Naoshima's neighbours). **Europe.** EES live; ETIAS 2027 — biometric queue now, permit later. **Long builds.** Changi T5, the cross-island people-mover, and the Johor rail link all progressing, none a 2026 booking.²

SOURCES 1. thenewstays.com; fun-japan.jp — Setouchi hotel openings (architect-designed villas, spring 2026; Shodoshima spa hotel, Mar 2026). 2. European Commission (EES live; ETIAS to 2027); Changi Airport Group; LTA — infrastructure timelines. Fares, dates and openings indicative and verified where possible; held items flagged.

THE GRAND TOUR • THE SETO INLAND SEA ART ISLANDS

Naoshima and Its Neighbours: Where You Go to Art by the Maker's Name

A cluster of small islands in the Seto Inland Sea has been turned, over three decades, into a place you travel to for single works by named hands — a Tadao Ando museum sunk into a hillside, a Monet room lit only by the sky, a water-drop pavilion, a yellow pumpkin on a pier. This is not a festival year, which is the good news. The permanent art is all open, and the crowds are thinner.

Naoshima is the anchor. The Chichu Art Museum — Ando's, mostly underground, lit by natural light — holds a room of Monet water lilies you enter in socks, a Turrell you walk into, a De Maria you climb; tickets are timed, booked online in fifteen-minute slots, and the weekends sell out.¹ Nearby sit the Benesse House Museum, art hung through a working hotel, and the Lee Ufan Museum. In the old village of Honmura, the Art House Project has turned empty houses into single installations — one a Turrell dark-room you sit in until your eyes rewrite it.

The islands reward the ferry-hop. Teshima, twenty minutes on, holds what many trip reports call the real highlight — a concrete water-drop shell by Ryue

Nishizawa where springs of water bead and run across the floor, and nothing else; Inujima turned a ruined copper refinery into a museum; the Kusama pumpkins, red at the port and yellow on the old pier, are the photographs everyone comes for.² That yellow one has a story that suits this weekend's book: it stood from 1994, was washed into the sea and broken by a typhoon in 2021, and was rebuilt ten per cent thicker to stand again.

Getting there from Singapore is a connection, not a flight: no direct service to the gateway cities, so the standard play is Kansai, the bullet train to Okayama, then a local run to Uno port and the twenty-minute ferry across.³ The soft yen flatters the whole trip; for the live rate, see the Macro desk (p14).

SINGAPORE TO THE ISLANDS

- Singapore → Osaka (KIX) · ~6.5–7h
- Shinkansen → Okayama · ~45 min
- Local line → Uno port
- Ferry → Naoshima · ~20 min, ~¥680

A Meridian original. Ferry via Shikoku Kisen; times/fares indicative, verify at booking.

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

The most-repeated line is "stay overnight" — day-trippers get the crowded midday version; those who sleep on the island get the pumpkins at dawn and the museums after the last ferry. The near-consensus dissent: Chichu is polarising, tickets are hard, waits can run to an hour; a vocal camp rates Teshima the true highlight; and a day trip from Kyoto or Osaka is "too rushed."

r/JapanTravel; TripAdvisor Naoshima; trip-report blogs — characterised

¥2,500

A TIMED WEEKDAY CHICHU TICKET (¥2,700 WEEKENDS), BOOKED ONLINE IN A 15-MINUTE SLOT; THE UNO-NAOSHIMA FERRY IS ~¥680 FOR A 20-MINUTE CROSSING¹

THE SCEPTIC • YOU DON'T NEED A FESTIVAL YEAR

The wisdom that you must come for the Triennale is wrong — this is not a festival year, and the permanent art is fully open with fewer crowds. And "Naoshima equals the pumpkin" undersells it: the overnighters who rate the islands highest point to Teshima's water pavilion and Honmura's art houses. Plan the closed days — most sites shut Mondays — before the photo.

Setouchi Explorer; Benesse Art Site calendar — characterised

ART ARCHITECTURE FAMILY-DOABLE

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Timed tickets. Chichu and Teshima need advance online slots — a reservation change was posted for autumn, so check first. **Closed days.** Most sites shut Mondays. **Around.** Naoshima is hilly — rent an e-bike or take the town bus.

SOURCES 1. Benesse Art Site Naoshima; trip.com — Chichu Art Museum (Ando; Monet/Turrell/De Maria; timed online tickets ¥2,500 weekday/¥2,700 weekend, 15-min slots; reservation-system change posted for ~1 Aug 2026, verify). 2. Benesse Art Site; CNN Travel; The Art Newspaper — Teshima Art Museum (Ryue Nishizawa/Rei Naito); Inujima Seirenscho; Kusama pumpkins (yellow first shown 1994, destroyed by Typhoon Lupit 9 Aug 2021, reinstalled 4 Oct 2022, reinforced). 3. Shikoku Kisen; naoshima.net — routing via Kansai + Shinkansen to Okayama + Uno ferry (~20 min, ~¥680); Takamatsu the alternative base. FX read: see The Macro Desk (p14).

THE GRAND TOUR · SETO, IN PRACTICE

When to Come, Where to Sleep, and What the Islands Cost

The art is the reason; the logistics are the trip. Come in the shoulder seasons, base yourself to beat the ferry crowd, and budget for museum fees that add up faster than the crossings. With a twelve-year-old, the ferries are a feature and the water-drop pavilion is the surprise hit.

Timing decides the trip. Spring and autumn are the windows — mild, clear, ferry-friendly; high summer is hot, humid and typhoon-prone (the season that took the pumpkin), and winter brings the real spoiler, the annual maintenance closures that shutter parts of the art site for weeks.¹ Overlay the weekly rhythm on top: most museums close Mondays, so a Monday arrival is a wasted day. Build the itinerary around the closed days first and the sights second, which is the opposite of how most people plan it.

Where you sleep is the other lever. The winning move, the forums agree, is to stay on Naoshima itself — Ando's Benesse House is the signature museum-hotel, with after-hours access to the galleries for guests, and island guesthouses fill the cheaper end — so you have the pumpkins and the museums in the still hours the day-trippers miss.² Takamatsu, back on the main island, offers the widest hotel choice, the ferries to several islands, and the udon; Okayama makes a clean first or last night by the bullet-train

line. The Benesse House rate is the trip's big-ticket line; the ferries, by contrast, are pocket change.

Two more practicalities. Eat where the region is strong: Kagawa is Japan's "udon prefecture," and a bowl-hopping lunch of small servings at a few counters is a meal and an itinerary at once, at a few hundred yen a bowl.³ And with a child, lean into what works — the ferries are a genuine highlight, the Kusama pumpkins are photo magnets, and Teshima's water pavilion, improbably, tends to be the piece a twelve-year-old talks about after. Just pace the hushed, no-photograph, timed-entry museums; two done well beats five rushed.

Netted out, the trip costs less than it looks and rewards more than it rushes. Ferries and udon are pocket change; the museum fees and a night at Benesse House are where the money goes, and the soft yen takes the edge off both (p14). Give it three days rather than one — the islands punish the checklist and reward the traveller who lets the last ferry leave without them.

Plan around the closed days, not the photographs.

¥2,300

A TESHIMA ART MUSEUM TICKET (FREE UNDER SIXTEEN) — THE PIECE MANY OVERNIGHTERS RATE ABOVE CHICHU; MUSEUM FEES, NOT FERRIES, ARE WHERE THE BUDGET GOES²

THE CHATTER · THE HONEST FOOD NOTE

Kagawa's udon is the sleeper reason to base in Takamatsu — a self-serve, order-a-small, hit-several-counters ritual the locals call udon-hopping, at prices that feel like a rounding error. On the islands themselves, lunch is café fare between museums; keep expectations there modest and save the appetite for the mainland.

Tabelog; iamafoodblog — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · THE PASSES AND THE RUSH

Two honest cautions. The multi-museum passes are not always the saving they look — price the sites you will actually reach in a day against the pass before buying — and the island-to-island ferries are seasonal and sparse, so a "three islands in a day" plan is how people end up seeing none of them properly. This is a two-or-three-day trip done slowly, not a checklist.

TripAdvisor Setouchi; trip reports — characterised

THE READER'S FIT

Season. Late spring or October–November; avoid the typhoon-season high summer and the winter maintenance weeks. **Base.** A night on Naoshima for the quiet; Takamatsu for choice and udon. **Money.** Ferries cheap; museum fees add up; Benesse House the splurge — softened by the yen (p14). **Kids.** E-bikes, ferries, and the water pavilion.

SOURCES 1. Setouchi Explorer; Benesse Art Site (seasons; Monday closures; winter maintenance shutdowns; Triennale every 3 years, 2026 a non-festival year). 2. Benesse House (Ando museum-hotel, guest after-hours access; rate held); Teshima Art Museum (¥2,300, free under 16); island guesthouses. 3. iamafoodblog; art-takamatsu.com — Kagawa "udon prefecture," udon-hopping (~¥200–400 a bowl). Held/unverified: Benesse House nightly rate; Takamatsu–Naoshima ferry time; some museum fees. Forum sentiment characterised, hard claims flagged.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

October Opens with a Sprint, and a Kyushu November Worth the Flight

Singapore's autumn fills up behind the first-ever Sprint; a run of stadium nights piles into the same weeks; and in Japan, a Gifu festival and a Fukuoka sumo tournament each earn a flight. Book the fast-movers now.

this story  

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

9–11
Oct

★ F1 Singapore Airlines Grand Prix

MARINA BAY · THE FIRST-EVER SINGAPORE SPRINT — SPRINT QUALIFYING FRI, SPRINT SAT, THE GRAND PRIX SUN · THE THREE-DAY WALKABOUT IS THE FAMILY VALUE PLAY, AND MARINA BAY ROOMS ARE CLIMBING NOW¹

2–3
Oct

The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn

NATIONAL STADIUM · TWO NIGHTS, WITH CREEPY NUTS GUESTING · FILLS DOWNTOWN HOTELS THE WEEKEND BEFORE THE RACE · CHECK RESALE FOR RETURNS

17
Oct

BIGBANG — 20/26 World Tour

NATIONAL STADIUM · 20TH-ANNIVERSARY SHOW, G-DRAGON/TAEYANG/DAESUNG · REPORTED S\$158–498 · ON GENERAL SALE, HIGH SELL-OUT RISK

4
Nov

LANY

SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · ON SALE (TICKETMASTER) · A DAUGHTER-FRIENDLY MIDWEEK POP NIGHT

10–11
Nov

My Chemical Romance

SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · FIRST REGIONAL SHOW IN OVER A DECADE, TWO NIGHTS · MOVE EARLY FOR THE BETTER NIGHT

29
Oct–
15
Nov

Cats the Musical

SANDS THEATRE, MBS · THE LLOYD WEBBER CLASSIC · REPORTED S\$68–238 · A STRONG PARENT-AND-DAUGHTER NIGHT

to 30
Nov

Dinosaurs: Extinctions & Us

SCIENCE CENTRE + LEE KONG CHIAN NATURAL HISTORY MUSEUM · A 40-METRE PATAGOTITAN AND SIX EXTINCTIONS · THE STANDOUT FAMILY DAY FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD²

19
Sep

Kit Chan — Atrium Live

SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · A HOMEGROWN ICON, A POLISHED ADULT NIGHT · ON SALE

20
Sep

Belle & Sebastian

ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL · SCOTTISH INDIE MAINSTAYS, REPORTED FROM S\$98 · A GROWN-UP NIGHT OUT

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

19–21
Sep

★ Tokyo Game Show 2026

MAKUHARI MESSE, CHIBA · PUBLIC DAYS · THE 30TH EDITION, ~3,500 BOOTHS, ~300,000 VISITORS EXPECTED · ADVANCE TICKETS ONLY, A HIT WITH A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD³

8–22
Nov

★ Kyushu Basho — Grand Sumo

FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · TICKETS ON SALE ~19 SEP · WEEKENDS AND THE FINAL THREE DAYS GO WITHIN THE HOUR · GENUINELY KID-FRIENDLY, A HALF-DAY OUT⁴

9–10
Oct

Takayama Autumn Festival

TAKAYAMA, GIFU · ONE OF JAPAN'S THREE GREAT FESTIVALS, ELEVEN ORNATE FLOATS AND A 9 OCT LANTERN PARADE · NO TICKET, BUT THE TOWN IS TINY — BOOK LODGING FAR AHEAD

Sep–
Oct

Cosmos Festival

SHOWA KINEN PARK, TOKYO · SOME FOUR MILLION COSMOS IN BLOOM · FREE, SEASONAL, FAMILY-EASY IF A TOKYO LEG LINES UP

3
Nov

Lexus Melbourne Cup

FLEMINGTON, MELBOURNE · "THE RACE THAT STOPS A NATION" · A SPRING-CARNIVAL LONG WEEKEND IF AUSTRALIA CALLS

to 3
Nov

teamLab — A Forest Where Gods Live

MIFUNEYAMA RAKUEN, SAGA (KYUSHU) · AN IMMERSIVE NIGHT WALK OF NATURE AND LIGHT · PAIRS GEOGRAPHICALLY WITH THE FUKUOKA SUMO

PLANNING NOTES

THE FAST-MOVERS

October is the home pinch point. The F1 debut Sprint (9–11 Oct), The Weeknd (2–3 Oct) and BIGBANG (17 Oct) crowd the month — book grandstands and race-weekend hotels now.

Japan alerts. Tokyo Game Show public tickets are advance-only, and the Kyushu sumo release lands about 19 Sep; set a mid-September alarm and target a weekday for availability.

SOURCES 1. F1 Singapore GP, 9–11 Oct 2026 (first Singapore Sprint) — RacingNews365; formula1.com. 2. Science Centre Singapore / Lee Kong Chian Natural History Museum (Dinosaurs exhibition; Patagotitan) — confirm end date at booking. 3. Tokyo Game Show 2026, public days 19–21 Sep (30th edition, ~3,500 booths, advance-only) — Nikkei xTrend / CESA. 4. Kyushu Basho, 8–22 Nov 2026, Fukuoka (tickets ~19 Sep) — Japan Cheapo. Concert dates/prices via listing aggregation (The Weeknd, BIGBANG, LANY, My Chemical Romance, Cats, Melbourne Cup, Takayama, Cosmos Festival) — reconfirm at booking; Oasis Tokyo Dome unverified, held off the page.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

A Three-Star Room Reopens, a Katong Institution Travels, and a Garden House Finally Launches

Three fresh reasons to book — and the honesty rule for the rest. The marquee is a three-Michelin-star kitchen back from a refurbishment; the heritage pick is a kaya-toast institution's first step out of Katong; and the garden house we called too-new last issue now has its opening date.

The marquee is a homecoming. Zén, the three-Michelin-starred room on Bukit Pasoh — Björn Frantzén's Singapore flagship — has reopened after a three-month refurbishment with a new tasting menu, and it sits about as far up the market as the city goes.¹ This is an occasion, not a weeknight table, and the reopening is the peg: a settled three-star reinventing its room and its menu at once. Book well ahead; at this tier the counter is small and the calendar fills months out. The reopening details are as reported; confirm the menu and price when you reserve.

The heritage pick is a first step out of the old neighbourhood. Chin Mee Chin, the Katong kaya-toast institution, has opened its first outlet beyond its home shophouse, at NEX in Serangoon — the charcoal-toast-and-soft-eggs kopitiam format carried into a mall, which is either sacrilege or

sensible depending on which uncle you ask.² It is family-easy, affordable, and the safest crowd-pleaser on the page. The occasion pick, Tembusu — the Straits-dining house in the Botanic Gardens' Ginger Garden we flagged as too-new last issue — now has its official launch on 3 September; the setting is the draw, and the food is finally about to be judged.³

And a clutch of names worth a line, not a paragraph. A Tokyo charcoal-teishoku grill and a value Italian we covered when they opened are now bedding in rather than launching; Korea's Mom's Touch has returned with a chicken-burger outlet, and a haenyeo-themed Korean pub has taken the Arts House courtyard.⁴ Read all of the newest as first impressions, not settled verdicts — the fresh three are days or weeks old, and a three-star's refurbished menu takes a few services to find its feet.

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE MEDIA & SOCIALS SAY

Across the local food press the three sort cleanly. Zén's reopening is the fine-dining event of the season, sold on the refurbishment and the new menu rather than a verdict yet. Chin Mee Chin's NEX move is the debate — heritage-toast purists split on whether the charcoal magic survives a mall unit. Tembusu is still the garden occasion, judged on setting until the kitchen is.

Time Out SG; Eatbook; City Nomads; The Ordinary Patrons — summarised

THE SCEPTIC · ROTATE, AND DON'T RE-RATE

Keep the honesty rule and the New-Peg Test. The venues we covered at their openings — a value Italian, a Tokyo grill, a Labubu bakery — get a callback line, not a second review; re-listing an opening without a new peg is exactly the drift this column avoids. And the three fresh names are too young for a settled verdict: a reopening menu, a heritage format in a new room, a garden house days from launch. Book the reopening for the occasion; treat the rest as first impressions.

desk judgement; coverage-ledger discipline

ZÉN · THREE-STAR REOPENING

CHIN MEE CHIN · NEX

TEMBUSU · LAUNCHES 3 SEP

CALLBACKS · ASSAGGI / POP

SOURCES 1. City Nomads; Time Out SG — Zén (Bukit Pasoh; Björn Frantzén group; three Michelin stars) reopened after a ~3-month refurbishment with a new tasting menu, Aug 2026 — reopening as reported, confirm menu/price at booking. 2. City Nomads; Eatbook — Chin Mee Chin (Katong kaya-toast institution) first outlet beyond Katong, at NEX Serangoon, Aug 2026. 3. FACT; The Ordinary Patrons — Tembusu (Botanic Gardens, Ginger Garden; Fleursophy Group; official launch 3 Sep 2026); food too new to call. 4. City Nomads; Time Out SG — callbacks: Charcoal Grill Shinpachi (No. 80) and Assaggi (No. 85) now open; Mom's Touch return (18 Cross); Jeju Haenyeo (The Arts House). Reception summarised across food media; newest venues are first impressions, not settled verdicts.

THE LONG READ · THE UNDERCURRENT

Copied Out by Hand

In the most wired country on earth, a generation is spending its evenings transcribing novels into notebooks, one sentence at a time, in silence. Korea calls it pilsa. It is the analog counter-movement crystallising at the exact moment a machine learned to write for free — and Korea is where it surfaces first because Korea is furthest in.

this story  

On a weekday evening in Seoul the quietest room in the building is the one that is full. A dozen people sit at a long table in an independent bookshop, each with a notebook and a pen, each copying passages from a novel by hand — slowly, deliberately, for an hour or so, saying nothing. The practice has a name, pilsa, and until recently it was a rote study drill, the thing a Korean student did to memorise a text. Since late 2024 it has become something else: a nationwide lifestyle, a hashtag with hundreds of thousands of posts, and a full consumer category with its own economics.¹

The numbers are the tell that this is a movement and not a mood. Sales of pilsa books — editions printed with blank lines beside the text, made to be copied into — jumped by a figure the country's largest chain put at nearly seven hundred per cent year on year; the count of new pilsa titles rose sharply, and a major

online bookseller reported several times as many handwriting titles in the first months of the year as the year before.² Around them, an entire adjacent economy has bloomed: book covers, bookmarks, fountain pens funded by the crowd, the notebook as an object of desire. The most striking data point sits underneath all of it — Koreans in their twenties are the only age group whose reading is rising, in a country where adult reading otherwise keeps falling.³

It did not come from nowhere. The wider "text hip" wave — reading reframed as stylish, photogenic, worth being seen doing — took off in 2024, given a national push when a Korean writer won the Nobel and her publisher rushed out pilsa editions of her novels. But the thing that has deepened through 2026 is narrower and stranger than reading-as-image. It is the act of copying itself: not the book on the shelf, but the hour spent transcribing it.

The value has migrated from the visible outcome — a book on your shelf — to the invisible process: an hour you spent, unshareable except as a photograph of the page.

~693%

THE REPORTED YEAR-ON-YEAR JUMP IN PILSA-BOOK SALES AT KOREA'S BIGGEST CHAIN — A RETAILER'S OWN CATEGORY TALLY, ECHOED ACROSS THE KOREAN PRESS²

THE READING · WHAT THE PRACTITIONERS SAY

Participants describe it, as reported in the Korean press, less as nostalgia than as a deliberate counter-move — "transcriptive meditation," a slow dialogue between the copier and the author, one of the few acts a person still fully authors alone now that chatbots draft the emails and summarise the articles. A 2026 trend report calls pen-and-paper practices "quietly radical" precisely because the machine now writes so much of everything else.

Korea Herald; Seoul Economic Daily; JoongAng — characterised

SOURCES 1. Korea Herald, "From 'text hip' to 'writing hip'; 'What Korea is reading in 2026' — pilsa as a nationwide practice and consumer category (late 2024 →). 2. Seoul Economic Daily (English), 26 Apr 2026 (pilsa-book sales +692.8% y/y, Kyobo category data — retailer-reported, flagged); new-title and Aladin handwriting-title counts, Korean press. 3. Korea Herald, "Reading declines again in Korea, but 20-somethings show rebound" (Ministry of Culture national reading survey). Platform sentiment characterised, not quoted.

THE LONG READ · FROM RITUAL TO RETAIL

An Old Spiritual Discipline, Repurposed for a Brand-New Problem

The deep lineage is what makes pilsa a cleaner story than vinyl or film cameras. Copying a text by hand is not a retro affectation dredged up for the feed; it is a centuries-old contemplative technology. Korean Buddhism has *sagyeong*, the devotional hand-copying of sutras; Confucian study was, for centuries, transcription — you learned a text by writing it out, and the writing was the learning.¹ What has happened in 2026 is that this old practice has re-entered the market as a *product*, its slowness rebranded as the point, at the precise moment a new machine made the labour of writing optional. The answer to a brand-new problem turned out to be very old.

And here is the contradiction that gives the trend its engine. A movement ostensibly about slowness, interiority and un-optimised time has instantly generated its own retail ecosystem — a category growing at nearly seven hundred per cent, branded stationery, crowdfunded pens, dedicated pilsa cafés, even a fashion offshoot the Korean press has labelled “poetcore,” dressing like someone who copies poems by hand.² The backlash against consumption

becomes, with startling speed, a thing to consume. That is not a flaw in the movement; it is the fuel. A culture that has commodified every other form of attention has learned to sell the refusal of it too.

The sceptics have the obvious question, and they are right to ask it: can a practice this aestheticised outlive its hashtag? Much of pilsa's visible life is a stream of carefully-styled photographs of pens and pages — the process made shareable after all, which is the very thing it was supposed to escape. But the doubt cuts both ways. The photograph is the residue; the hour is the thing, and the hour is real whether or not it is posted. Even if the aesthetic fades, what it points to does not.

There is a third reading, quieter than the other two. Pilsa is a refusal of speed itself — of the optimisation logic that treats every spare hour as something to be made productive. To sit and copy a paragraph you could photograph in a second is to reject the premise that faster is always better; in a culture that has metered attention to its last minute, that refusal is a small radical act, which is exactly why it now sells.

The backlash against consumption becomes, with startling speed, a thing to consume. That is not a flaw in the story. It is the story.

THE READING · THE PARADOX GENERATION

The split screen is the whole argument. The same twenty-somethings who made a chatbot overtake the home-grown portal for search, and who power one of the world's fastest-growing AI-companion apps, are the ones sitting in silence copying novels by hand. They are not rejecting the machine. They are drawing a line around the one thing they will not hand it: the authorship of their own attention.

Korea Herald; Korean tech press — characterised

57 → 81

NEW PILSA TITLES PUBLISHED IN A SINGLE YEAR, UP MORE THAN FORTY PER CENT — THE SUPPLY SIDE RACING TO MEET THE NOTEBOOKS³

+198%

THE REPORTED JUMP IN A YEAR IN BOOK REVIEWS WRITTEN BY KOREAN READERS AGED THIRTEEN TO TWENTY ON ONE MAJOR PLATFORM — THE YOUNG END OF THE SAME TURN TOWARD READING AS SOMETHING YOU DO, NOT CONSUME³

THE THREADS

Lineage. *Sagyeong* and Confucian transcription — a spiritual discipline, not a fad. **Paradox.** A slowness movement that spawned a 700%-growth retail category. **Authorship.** When the machine writes for free, the deliberately “uncreative” act of copying becomes proof of attention. **Doubt.** Whether an aestheticised ritual outlives the feed that carries it.

SOURCES 1. On *sagyeong* (Buddhist sutra-copying) and transcription in Confucian study — cultural-history background; Korea Herald coverage of pilsa's lineage. 2. Korea Herald, “Dress like a poet” (poetcore offshoot); Seoul Economic Daily (pilsa cafés, stationery, crowdfunded pens). 3. Yes24 data via Korean press (reviews by readers aged 13–20 +198.1% in 2024; adjacent book-merch growth). Platform figures are retailer-reported; sentiment characterised, not invented.

THE LONG READ · WHY KOREA FIRST

The Canary Copies Out a Warning the Rest of Us Will Recognise

Ask why this surfaced in Korea before anywhere else and the answer is that Korea is furthest along the road everyone is on. It is among the most wired societies on the planet, an early and heavy adopter of generative AI, and a place that runs its young people harder than almost any peer. A country that arrives first at the exhaustion tends to arrive first at the antidote — which is why the pilsa boom looks less like a Korean curiosity than a bulletin from a near future the rest of us are driving toward.¹ When the big Western papers write this up in a few weeks, as a "slow living" or "AI backlash" feature, they will be describing something Korea has already been living for a year.

The larger shift it signals is a bifurcation. As artificial intelligence eats the *middle* of cognitive work — the drafting, the summarising, the searching that used to fill a knowledge worker's day — cultural value is migrating to the two ends the machine cannot occupy. At one pole, instant, frictionless machine

convenience: the chatbot that writes the email in a second. At the other, slow, embodied, unmistakably human ritual: the hour spent copying a paragraph by hand precisely because nothing about it can be automated or outsourced. The comfortable middle — competent, effortful, human work — is exactly the ground the machine is claiming.

Which returns the whole weekend's book to a single question. The frame that comes off one factory under a dozen logos; the model whose weights are open but whose licence decides who may run them; the watch signed by the hand that restored its movement; the drone you solder yourself. Each is a version of the same instinct pilsa expresses at its purest: in an age that will happily do the work for you, the value is in the part you insist on doing yourself. The hand, as Bronowski had it, is the cutting edge of the mind — and it is the one edge you cannot lend to a machine.

As the machine eats the middle of cognitive work, value flees to the two ends it cannot occupy: instant convenience, and the slow ritual you insist on doing by hand.

THE READING · THE UNDER-THE-RADAR TEST

Pilsa passes the desk's test for a genuine undercurrent: searched against the five outlets we hold as the crossover line — the major American and British papers and wires — it has not yet been given a feature. The English-language coverage is Korea's own press and a scattering of niche blogs. It is pre-crossover, which is the whole point of telling you now.

search of NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT/Economist, Aug 2026
— no feature found

1

AGE GROUP IN KOREA WHOSE READING IS RISING — THE TWENTY-SOMETHINGS — EVEN AS THE NATIONAL FIGURE KEEPS FALLING; THE GENERATION MOST EXPOSED TO THE MACHINE, DRAWING THE FIRREST LINE²

THE ARGUMENT, IN A LINE

When a machine can write anything on demand, the scarce good stops being information and becomes **authorship** — the proof that a human mind spent the time. Korea got there first because Korea is deepest in. The West's version is coming; the pen was always going to be part of the answer.

SOURCES 1. Korea Herald; Korea JoongAng Daily — Korea as an early, heavy adopter of AI and a high-burnout society; pilsa framed as an analog counter-movement. 2. Korea Herald (Ministry of Culture reading survey; 20-somethings the sole rebound cohort). Under-the-radar check: name-searches of the major US/UK outlets, Aug 2026, returned no feature on pilsa; coverage confined to Korean English-language press and niche blogs.

THE LAST WORD

The maker behind the badge, and the hand you cannot outsource.

Read the weekend from the lifestyle desks down and one instinct keeps surfacing: the wish to know whose hand actually made the thing. A frame that turns out to share a factory line with a dozen designer logos (p6). A watch that is worth its price only because a named workshop restored a fifty-year-old movement and signed it (p10). A flying machine whose whole culture is that you solder it yourself (p15). Even the hard-news desks rhyme with it — a chip a company built rather than badged (p7), a model whose open weights come with a licence deciding who may run them (p8). The Undercurrent gave it a face: a Korean generation copying its books out by hand, in silence, because a machine now writes for free and the one thing worth keeping is the part you do yourself (p25). Bronowski's line, from the contents page, turns out to be the whole issue in six words — the hand is the cutting edge of the mind. The badge is easy to buy and easy to fake. The hand is the part that has to be earned, and the part no one can lend you. This weekend, that was the difference worth paying for.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES

Full per-page source lines appear in each desk's footer. Principal sources this issue: Al Jazeera; CNBC; CNN; Reuters; Bloomberg; Fortune; Washington Post; Japan Times; Federal Reserve; CME FedWatch; USAGOLD; TradingEconomics; EDB; MTI & MAS; MOM; Ministry of Finance; NVIDIA; The Register; TechCrunch; The New Stack; Hugging Face; PR Newswire; Engadget; TechRadar; Singer Reimagined; Hodinkee; Monochrome; Deadline; Rotten Tomatoes; Billboard; Nature/HSSC; Ministry of Education; Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports; MultiGP; Oscar Liang; DJI; CAAS; japan-guide; JNTO; Benesse Art Site Naoshima; Shikoku Kisen; Korea Herald; Seoul Economic Daily; Korea JoongAng Daily. Market levels around the US close, Fri 28 Aug 2026. The Family and Fitness desks are general guidance, not medical advice; The Macro Desk is market explanation, not investment advice; images are honestly labelled and representative where noted.